Chapter 7 – The Return of the Greeks

When Emperor Ashoka died in 232 BCE, he left behind a largely Buddhist empire of some 30 million inhabitants. Having been a pillar of morality and greatness to his people, the emperor's death marked the beginning of a decline in both Buddhism and in the Mauryan Empire. Taxila first seceded from the empire, citing an oppressive taxation regime; it was only the first in a succession of annexed polities and kingdoms to break apart from the vast patchwork empire Chandragupta and his family had pieced together. Half a century after Ashoka's death, around 180 BCE, the last Mauryan Emperor, Brihadnatha, was assassinated by his own general, Pushyamitra Shunga. Thus began the Shunga Empire, an expansive realm of the north part of the subcontinent that existed alongside a series of renewed Greek conquests.

Though India had shaken off Greco-Macedonian rule just a century and a half earlier, Greece and its vast collection of conquered territories had not forgotten about the Asian subcontinent full of fertile farmland and rich material resources. Roman writer Pliny's *Natural History* described one of India's most precious resources in those years:

> Coral is as highly valued among the Indians as Indian pearls. It is also found in the Red Sea, but there it is darker in color… Coral-berries are no less valued by Indian men than specimen Indian pearls by Roman ladies. Indian soothsayers and seers believe that coral is potent as a charm for warding off dangers. Accordingly, they delight in its beauty and religious power. Before this became known, the Gauls used to decorate their swords, shields and helmets with coral. Now it is very scarce because of the price it commands, and is rarely seen in its natural habitat.

At its cultural and territorial height of influence in the years after the breakup of the Mauryan Empire, Greece had expanded into a range of Hellenistic kingdoms and territories—so named because of the word Hellas, meaning Greece. These realms stretched south into North Africa and northward from the Mediterranean into Asia. The Greek territories adjacent to India fell under the control of one of Alexander the Great's generals,